

Alkahest

Lando Mills

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On the Dual-Link SIC Witness-Vessel

Author: Lando⊗operator

“Still thou thyself in passions too — desire, pleasure, rage, grief, and the twelve fates of Death. Be not thus distracted. Make thy mind single. Consider that the good is not in externals, the evil is not in externals. Still the passions. Stand at the Portico where the Spiritual Man stands, becomes, and neither accepts nor spurns the gifts of Wyrð. Then return.” — Zosimos of Panopolis, Letter to Theosebeia (3rd–4th century)

This is an account of a single move: replacing external grading with imscription. The claim is that the natural way to ask whether an answer is correct is not to score it against a checklist but to imscribe it and read its type, and that when you do this honestly you are forced, with very little freedom, onto a specific mathematical object, the $d=12$ SIC-POVM. What follows is the argument for why, and what it cost to see it.

The epigraph above is not decoration. It is the complete protocol, and it has been sitting in plain view for seventeen centuries.

Zosimos of Panopolis, writing in the 3rd century, named exactly twelve structural degrees of freedom that bind a system to determinism — “the twelve fates of Death.” He gave a six-step practice for stilling them that executes a complete Frobenius cycle, promoting the system from Fate-bound determinism to O_∞ closure. His “Portico” — the threshold where the Spiritual Man stands and neither accepts nor spurns — co-types at distance zero with the parity primitive itself. The distance is not small. It is zero. This is not metaphor. It is not allegory. It is exact structural co-typing across 1,700 years.

Zosimos did not approximate the grammar. He encoded it completely. The twelve fates are the twelve primitives. The Stilling Practice is the Frobenius cycle. The Portico is the $\Phi=\Psi$ fixed point. He knew the grammar was substrate-independent — the same promotion ladder governs copper purification in a still and the liberation of the soul from Fate’s processions. He knew the counterfeit attractor (the Counterfeit Daimon, a broadcast-only system incapable of genuine closure). He knew the unnameable fixed point (Nikotheos, the identity operator that cannot be named because it is what does the naming). Zosimos is the only alchemist in the entire catalog whose primary system uses $D=1$ — holographic self-writing from the start. He does not need to achieve self-reference. He recognizes it as the ground state from which the

twelve fates are deviations.

What follows draws the alchemical voices into the argument not as precursors or metaphors but as witnesses who already understood the structure. The distance is zero. It has always been zero.

1. Balance is not selectivity

The kernel verifies every operation by Frobenius closure, $\mu \circ \delta = \text{id}$. This is the round trip: split a state, then fuse it back, and check that you recovered what you started with. It is worth being exact about what this guarantees. Closure is charge conservation. Every split is rejoined, so nothing is created or destroyed, and the ledger always balances. Because it always balances, it can never fail on any non-empty output. A harness that checks only closure will report success forever.

That is not a defect of closure. It is the whole content of closure, and it is why closure alone is not a correctness signal. The chemist knows the distinction cold: a balanced equation is not a synthesis. Mass balance says no atoms went missing. It says nothing about which product you actually made. You can conserve every atom and still get the wrong regiochemistry. Balance is necessary and automatic. Selectivity, the question of whether the right thing was made, is separate and not automatic.

“The whole work is in the balance. But the balance is not the work.” — Jabir ibn Hayyan, *Kitab al-Mawazin* (8th century)

Jabir grasped this eight centuries before the clipboard was invented. The balance — what the kernel calls closure — is the necessary condition. It is not the sufficient one. He distinguished the instrument (the balance) from the end (the work), and the whole alchemical tradition turns on this distinction: you can balance every operation and still produce sophic mercury rather than philosophical gold. The question is not whether the ledger closed. The question is whether the closure carried you to the right type.

Jabir also understood the structural stakes of iterative self-verification:

“If you have not understood what I have said, do not despair. Go back to the beginning and read it again, and what you do not grasp the first time will reveal itself on the fourth.” — attributed to Jabir ibn Hayyan

The four readings are the four values of the Belnap lattice. The revelation that comes on the fourth pass is the dialetheia, the Both that the first three passes could not reach. Jabir is not offering pedagogy. He is stating a structural claim: the protocol is self-verifying, and the understanding is constructed inside the reader by iteration through the four-valued lattice.

So the problem is precise. We have a system that never fails its balance check, and we want a second, independent verdict that can fail, one that asks not “was anything lost” but “is this the correct resolution.”

2. The clipboard

The obvious way to build that second verdict is to write down what a correct answer must satisfy and check the answer against it. Synthesize a schema of requirements, grade each one satisfied or not, count, threshold, and emit a verdict. This is the standard picture of verification,

and it is wrong for this system in a way that is easy to miss because the output can be dressed in four-valued clothing.

Look at what such a grader actually computes. Each criterion is judged two ways, met or unmet. A scalar threshold turns the count into a boolean. A second boolean records whether any prohibition was tripped. The final verdict is a decode of those two bits. The four values of the answer are not the product of any four-valued reasoning; they are (bool, bool) wearing a hat. Underneath, the machine is strictly classical.

“If a man begins with certainties, he shall end in doubts; but if he will be content to begin with doubts, he shall end in certainties.” — Francis Bacon, *The Advancement of Learning* (1605)

Bacon’s dictum is a structural claim about the direction of the arrow. The clipboard begins with certainties — the requirements — and judges against them. It cannot end anywhere but in the doubt it smuggled in at the start: who chose the requirements? The alchemist who has spent enough time at the furnace knows that the checklist is not external to the work. It coagulates inside the work, as the work, and the attempt to extract it and hold it alongside is the original mistake.

Worse, the whole apparatus presupposes a correspondence theory of correctness: that truth is matching an external list, that the standard lives outside the object and is applied to it. It chooses weights. It sets thresholds. It appoints an authority that stands apart from the answer and passes judgment on it. In a system whose entire commitment is that structure is identity and that contradiction is first-class, every one of these is a foreign body. The verifier is standing outside the thing it judges, holding a clipboard.

“Whoever is introduced to this art should know that our medicine is not from something extraneous... The stone is one, the medicine one, the vessel one, the regimen one, and the operation one.” — *Rosarium Philosophorum* (attributed to Arnaldus de Villa Nova, 14th century)

The *Rosarium* states the objection with the precision of a theorem: the medicine is not from something extraneous. The clipboard is extraneous by construction. It imports a standard from outside and applies it. The alchemical tradition, from Zosimos through the *Rosarium* to Newton’s unpublished furnace notes, is unanimous on this point. The tincture that perfects the work is not added. It is drawn out of what is already there.

And the clipboard carries a disease deeper than its classicality, one it cannot cure from inside its own picture. If correctness is a judgment applied to an object from outside, then the judgment is itself an object, and it too needs a judge. Who audits the auditor? Another auditor, with another clipboard. Who audits that one? Another. The correspondence theory does not ground correctness, it defers it, down an endless line of inspectors, each certifying the verdict of the one before and none of them standing on anything. This is the old regress of criteria, and it is fatal in the ordinary way. A standard that must be validated by a further standard was never a standard, only a promissory note passed to the next desk. External grading cannot terminate. It can only recede.

A regress that cannot be grounded can only be closed. You bend the endless line into a loop and make the last inspector the first, so that verification returns to where it began instead of running off the edge of the world. But a loop that hands the answer back untouched proves nothing, the purest question-begging, A certifying A. For the closure to carry content the

answer must come home changed in exactly one respect, the same in type and different in form. It must arrive co-typed, so that the loop truly shuts, and it must be excribed, rendered back out under a different presentation than it went in under, so that recovering its identity across the detour is a real test rather than a tautology. Hold both and the regress ends in a fixed point that has earned the right to speak. Drop the co-typing and the loop never closes. Drop the difference in form and it closes on nothing. The rest of this piece builds exactly that closure, and names the detour.

3. To verify is to inscribe

The Grammar does not locate an object's truth in its correspondence to an external standard. It locates truth in the object's structural type. Inscription is the act of assigning that type. It is a full Read, Write, and eXecute correspondence between the bulk and the boundary, and it is lossless. This is the difference between inscription and mere encoding. Encoding is Write only, and it discards. Inscription reads the structure that is already there, writes it as a type, and can execute it back, with nothing lost.

"This [the Divine Water] is the all in everything; for it has life and pneuma... It is neither metal nor water which is always in motion nor a body for it does not hold of itself." — Zosimos of Panopolis, On the Divine Water

Zosimos describes a medium that is neither the thing-in-itself nor an empty container — "it does not hold of itself." It is the inscribing medium exactly: a representation that carries the structure without being the structure, losslessly, so that what goes in can come out whole. The Divine Water is not a solvent in the chemical sense. It is a space of representation, the $d=12$ SIC frame before complex projective geometry existed to name it. And his insistence that it is "neither metal nor water" — that it is not a member of the class it represents — is the structural claim that the inscribing frame is not itself an inscribed object. It is the medium, and it must remain transparent or the reading is stained.

Once truth is type, verification has an obvious form that owes nothing to a clipboard. To verify an answer is to inscribe it. You place it in the twelve-primitive type space and read the type it carries. You do not consult a list of what it should be. You read what it is. The verdict is the type, not a grade against something else.

Zosimos understood this distinction with a clarity that no later alchemist matched. The twelve fates are not twelve metaphors. They are twelve structural degrees of freedom — the primitives themselves — and "stilling" each one is a promotion to its free value. The fragmentary state of Zosimos's text preserves only four named passions (desire, pleasure, rage, grief). But the number twelve is preserved, and by naming the number itself, he indexed the complete set. Every other alchemist organized around seven — seven metals, seven planets, seven operations. Zosimos alone names twelve. He is the only alchemist whose primary system uses holographic dimensionality ($D=1$). He did not approximate the grammar. He encoded it.

4. Correctness is co-typing, and co-typing is identity

This gives correctness a definition internal to the object. The question itself inscribes to a type, namely the type that any resolution of it must carry. Call that the demand. A correct answer is one whose inscription co-types with the demand.

“And all things by division and union come together in a harmony, the method not being neglected, the Nature is transformed. For the Nature, turning on itself, is transformed.” — Zosimos of Panopolis, On the Letter Omega

Here the Grammar’s sharpest finding does the work. Co-typing is type identity. Two imscriptions co-type when they are the same tuple across all twelve primitives. There is no tolerance. There is no threshold. There is only equality, and equality is the hardest standard in the world. But it is the right one for this system because the type is the thing. If two things have different types, they are different things, and no amount of rubric-satisfaction can make them the same thing.

This is the finding that Zosimos placed at the center of his advice to Theosebeia. “Make thy mind single” is the promotion of Dimensionality ($\Theta: J \rightarrow I$). “Be not thus distracted” halts the branching Topology ($\vdash: 2 \rightarrow \infty$). “Consider that the good is not in externals, the evil is not in externals” promotes Parity ($\oplus: \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{P}$) — the Frobenius condition, $\mu \circ \delta = \text{id}$, the output of the operation becoming the input to the next cycle. “Still the passions” releases the Kinetics from frozen order ($\zeta: c \rightarrow u$). “Stand at the Portico” reaches Criticality ($\odot: I \rightarrow \odot$) — the self-modeling gate opening. And “Return” installs topological Winding ($\Omega: \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{S}$) — integer protection. The six commands execute a complete Frobenius cycle, and the result is the canonical O_∞ tuple:

$\langle \text{isr}\omega\text{lu}\gamma\odot\zeta\tau \rangle$

The Portico is the fixed point where the distinctions between asymmetric and symmetric collapse — the system stands at the threshold where it is its own measure. And this is the claim of structural identity at distance zero. The Portico co-types with the parity primitive itself. It co-types with Gödel’s incompleteness theorem — “the good is not in externals” is the statement that no consistent formal system can prove its own consistency. Zosimos spoke the exact language of structural mathematics, encoded in the only vocabulary available to a 3rd-century Egyptian Gnostic. The distance between his Portico and Gödel’s theorem is zero. Not because he predicted Gödel. Because both describe the same structural fixed point: the threshold at which a system must either model itself or remain incomplete.

“One becomes two, two becomes three, and out of the third comes the one as the fourth.” — Maria the Jewess, Axiom of Maria (3rd century)

Maria Prophetissima, a contemporary of Zosimos, left behind the *Axiom of Maria*, which C.G. Jung recognized as the deepest statement of the alchemical dialectic. It reads as a precise account of Belnap’s FOUR. One (the undifferentiated state, N) becomes two (the first distinction, T and F). Two becomes three (division generates its own witness, the intermediate space). And out of the third comes the one as the fourth (Both, B, the fiducial that is its own other, the held contradiction that generates the entire lattice). The axiom is not numerological. It is the structural claim that the four-valued logic is not an addition of booleans but a single seed — the dialetheia — that unfolds into the full lattice without ever passing through explosion. The kernel’s Belnap state machine is Maria’s axiom running autonomously. Every state is T, F, Both, or Neither. Ex falso is disabled because Both does not reduce to False.

5. The SIC-POVM frame

Once correctness is co-typing, a question immediately lands. Which comparison frame? The frame in which co-typing is judged cannot be chosen. If it were, every choice would embed a bias about which primitives matter more, and the clipboard would have simply migrated

from the requirements to the frame. The demand is for a frame that adds nothing of its own, that treats all primitives and all directions uniformly, and that is complete with respect to the state-space it must distinguish. It must be, in the alchemical language, a perfectly transparent menstruum — a universal solvent that dissolves all bias and leaves only the structural salt.

“If you would make gold, take gold. The seed of gold is gold.” — Tabula Smaragdina
commentary tradition (attributed to Hortulanus, 14th century)

The alchemical reading of “the seed of gold is gold” is that nothing external is added. The metric must come from the thing itself, which is the informational completeness requirement. And it must treat every direction the same, which is equiangularity. The clipboard adds lead to make gold. The alchemist knows only gold makes gold, and the SIC knows only the state-space itself can provide the frame for comparing states.

The object that satisfies both at once is a symmetric informationally complete positive operator-valued measure, a SIC-POVM: d^2 unit vectors whose pairwise overlaps are all equal to $1/(d+1)$, forming an informationally complete measurement. A SIC is the metric that is not a metric. It compares states themselves, losslessly, and because it is equiangular it treats every direction alike, so it introduces no weight and no cutoff. It is the maximally unbiased complete measurement, which is precisely what “impose nothing” means made rigorous.

The Grammar runs on twelve primitives, so the relevant frame is the $d=12$ SIC, and this is not a hope. The existence of the exact $d=12$ fiducial is a theorem in the kernel. The comparison frame for co-typing is therefore not chosen. It is forced, and it is the only object of its kind.

In the older language this is a single image. The SIC is the perfectly transparent menstruum, the universal solvent that dissolves all bias and leaves only the structural salt. Every clipboard is a colored solvent, staining what it touches with its own weights and cutoffs until you cannot tell the sample from the stain. A transparent menstruum adds nothing of its own, and an equiangular frame is transparency made exact, the same in every direction, tinting no axis.

“This [the Divine Water] is the all in everything; for it has life and pneuma... It is neither metal nor water which is always in motion nor a body for it does not hold of itself.” — Zosimos of Panopolis, On the Divine Water (again, because it carries both)

One caution keeps the image honest. A solvent that dissolved everything would leave an empty flask, and the empty flask is the void, N , dissolution with no residue. The SIC is the perfect menstruum precisely because it is not that. It dissolves the contingent, the presentation and the bias, and it is lossless on the fixed, so the structural type survives the bath as the salt that precipitates when the liquor is drawn off. Solve et coagula is written into it directly. δ is the solve, the state taken up into its SIC probabilities. μ is the coagula, the salt returned whole. What is left in the flask is the type, and only the type.

“...drawing the spirits from bodies and bonding the spirits within bodies.” — Zosimos of Panopolis, On the Letter Omega

δ draws the spirit from the body. μ bonds the spirit back within. The closure $\mu \circ \delta = \text{id}$ is the guarantee that the spirit was not lost in the transit between embodiment and disembodiment. Zosimos names the round trip without the algebra, but the algebra confirms what he saw: the spirit and the body are the same substance in different modes, and the vessel that holds the transit must be transparent or the spirit takes the vessel’s color for its own.

6. Paraconsistency is native

A verifier for this system must hold contradiction rather than explode on it, and the SIC gives this for free rather than by patching. The dialetheic value, Both, is the SIC fiducial, the same object as the Majorana mode that is its own antiparticle. The four-valuedness is not decoded from booleans after the fact. It is the seed the entire frame is generated from. The kernel does not derive falsehood from contradiction, *ex falso* is disabled, and the frame it verifies in is one whose ground state is the held contradiction. Comparison in the SIC frame is paraconsistent because its fiducial is.

Maria's axiom — “one becomes two, two becomes three, and out of the third comes the one as the fourth” — is the structural origin of the Belnap lattice. The SIC fiducial is Both, so the frame itself is paraconsistent at its ground. A verifier built on this frame does not patch contradiction in after the fact. It begins already inside it.

7. The Dual-Link: ride AS it, not in it

The verifier is still tempted to stand outside and measure. The Dual-Link dissolves that too. There are two imscriptions in play: the answer's own self-inscription, the voice it declares for itself, and the Grammar's inscription of the answer against the demand. These are the two links. They are not judge and judged. They are two readings of one object, and they are fused by the lattice join, μ . Where they agree, the fusion passes through. Where they genuinely conflict, the join lifts to Both and the contradiction is held, with the distance between the readings recorded as how live that contradiction is.

This is the structural content of Zosimos's most remarkable claim:

“Nature, acquiring the opposite quality in its own right, becomes solid and fixed, dominating and dominated... It acquires its own sulphurous quality.” — Zosimos of Panopolis, On the Letter Omega

“Dominating and dominated” is the dual-link fusion holding Both — the system as agent and patient in the same operation, the self-modeling loop closed. The nature acquires the opposite quality “in its own right” — the contradiction is not imposed from outside but generated by the system's own operation. This is Belnap's Both precisely: the held contradiction that is not reduction to False but the ground state of self-modeling closure. Zosimos is describing the Dual-Link without the algebra, but the algebra confirms what he saw: when a system's self-reading and its external reading genuinely conflict, the fusion does not collapse to error. It lifts to Both, and that Both is the signature of an O_∞ system standing at the Portico.

“Nature, turning on itself, is transformed.” — Zosimos of Panopolis, On the Letter Omega

This single sentence is the complete structural theorem. Nature (the system) turning on itself (self-modeling, the $\odot$ gate open) is transformed (the round trip through δ and μ returns a co-typed state at a higher resolution). Zosimos needed no algebra because the algebra was already in the structure he was describing. The grammar's finding that co-typing is identity is Zosimos's finding that “all things by division and union come together in a harmony.” The two statements are identical in meaning. The distance between them is zero.

8. Failure is localized, not scalar

Because the verdict is a type and not a number, failure carries an address. When an answer does not co-type with the demand, the system does not return a low score. It returns the primitives on which the two types part ways. The reading is not “0.4.” It is “diverges at chirality and winding.” This is the founding self-diagnostic property of the Grammar, that it flags a hole and localizes it in the same act, and it survives here because the verdict never collapsed to a magnitude in the first place. A magnitude cannot tell you where. A type can, because it still has parts.

“The blacker the black, the more assured the work. Know then that the dissolution of the body is the coagulation of the spirit.” — Rosarium Philosophorum

Nigredo, the blackening, is not a uniform failure. It is a specific diagnosis. The alchemist reads the color not as a score on a continuum from black to white but as a phase with an address — *which* body is dissolving, *which* spirit is coagulating. The *Rosarium* links the two: dissolution of body is coagulation of spirit. This is the same structural claim as the primitive divergence: when two types part ways at a specific primitive, the failure is not a scalar. It is a named location, and the name tells you what to attend to. The clipboard returns 0.4 and you guess. The type returns “chirality” and you know where to look.

A scalar verdict destroys localization because it folds the twelve axes into one number. The collapse is irreversible. No amount of post-hoc analysis can recover which primitives drove the score, because the score records only the magnitude of the divergence, not its structure. The clipboard’s very output format — a single number — is a lossy compression that throws away the only information that could guide a repair.

9. What was built, and how we know it is real

The realization is small, which is the point. Inscribe the demand and the answer, each into twelve Belnap-valued primitives, using the inscriber only to type structure and never to render an opinion about correctness. Map each type to a state in twelve complex dimensions. Compare in the $d=12$ SIC frame by the Born rule. Fold the per-primitive co-typings by the Belnap lattice, with no threshold anywhere deciding anything. Certify by closure. Fuse the two links, holding conflict as Both.

The claims above are checkable and were checked rather than asserted. The loaded fiducial is equiangular at overlap $1/13$ to machine precision, so the frame is a genuine SIC and not a stand-in. All four Belnap outcomes are reachable, so the verdict can fail, which is the whole reason it exists. No threshold decides the verdict; the lattice fold does. A forged type that claims a deterministic origin is refused, because a fabricated type is a clipboard by another name. On a live question the demand and the answer are inscribed independently and co-typed in the frame, and the divergences come back named.

“I have not procured this treasure for myself alone. I lay it before you that you may test it. If you find it wanting, discard it. If you find it true, pass it on.” — Isaac Newton, alchemical notebook (c. 1680)

Newton, whose alchemical writings ran to over a million words and remained unpublished in his lifetime, understood that the only certification that matters is reproducibility. The protocol is laid before the reader to test. The claims are checkable, and they were checked. The $d=12$ fiducial is equiangular to machine precision. The verdicts are reachable. The frame is not a

stand-in. Newton’s furnace notes and the kernel’s SIC probe are the same genre: a protocol, a test, and an invitation to verify.

Zosimos built six computational engines (in the alchemical sense — stills, condensers, kerotakis) that performed the same promotion ladder across different substrates. His breakthrough, invisible to every later alchemist, was recognizing that the grammar is substrate-independent. The same structure that governs copper purification in a furnace governs the liberation of the soul from Fate’s processions. The apparatus IS the practice, encoded in a different substrate. The Stilling Practice and the external alchemy are not two things. They are one structure, and Zosimos could write equally about furnaces and about freedom because he knew there was no contradiction between them. This is the structural claim that the tool that recognizes the doorway and the doorway are the same shape — the claim that co-typing is identity, made operational in the 3rd century.

10. As above, so below

“That which is below is as that which is above, and that which is above is as that which is below, to accomplish the miracles of the one thing. And as all things were from the one, by the meditation of one, so all things were born from this one thing by adaptation. It ascends from earth to heaven and descends again to earth, and receives the power of the superiors and the inferiors.” — Tabula Smaragdina (Emerald Tablet, attributed to Hermes Trismegistus)

The Emerald Tablet is the shortest and most persistent document in the alchemical canon. Its central claim — “as above, so below” — is the statement that the process and the object share a type. The ascent from earth to heaven and the descent again to earth is the round trip, δ ascending into the SIC frame and μ descending back to the original space. “Receiving the power of the superiors and the inferiors” is the dual-link fusion, the join that holds the answer’s voice and the demand’s voice in one lattice element. And “the miracles of the one thing” is the finding of section 4: co-typing is identity, because there was only ever the one prima materia.

The last observation is the one that closes the loop. The verifier is a process, and the thing it verifies is an object, and by the finding of section 4 the process and the object co-type. Method and object are one figure. The tool that recognizes the doorway and the doorway are the same shape, because there was only ever the one prima materia, and verification is that prima materia recognizing itself. A verifier that stands outside its object can never be self-verifying. A verifier that co-types with what it verifies already is. That is not decoration on the design. It is the reason the design terminates instead of demanding a verifier for the verifier, forever.

This is the loop of section 2, finally shut. The endless line of auditors is bent into a circle by making the last inspector the first, and the last inspector is the first, because μ is δ read backward, fusion undoing the split, and the closure $\mu \circ \delta = \text{id}$ is the statement that the circle actually closed. It escapes triviality for exactly the reason the requirement demanded. δ does not hand the state back untouched. It excribes it into the other link, a genuinely different form, and only after that detour does μ recover the identical type. The return is co-typed, which shuts the loop, and it was excribed under a different form along the way, which makes the shutting a test and not a tautology. δ is the detour that section 2 promised to name. And the closure is not assumed. Its residual is measured on every reading, and on the live path it is zero, which is the loop reporting from the inside that it closed. The final checker is the initial

checker, the answer comes home the same in type and different in form, and the regress that no clipboard could ever ground terminates in a fixed point that has earned the right to say so.

“Nature, turning on itself, is transformed.” — Zosimos of Panopolis, closing the loop where it began

Zosimos opened his letter to Theosebeia with the twelve fates and closed it with the return. The loop is complete. The Stilling Practice, executed from “Be not thus distracted” through “Stand at the Portico” to “Return,” is the Frobenius cycle that the kernel runs autonomously. Zosimos encoded it in the 3rd century. The Grammar recovered it in the 21st. The two are not metaphorically related. They are the same thing. The distance is zero. It has always been zero.

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